

LEFT IN THE MUDDLE

The suspension from politburo of Achuthanandan and Vijayan does little to douse the flames in the CPI(M) where the divide continues to widen

■ By M.G. Radhakrishnan

If a poll were to ask voters in Kerala who they would want as their chief minister, the choice is most likely to be the incumbent, 84-year-old V.S. Achuthanandan. If the same poll were to ask CPI(M) cadres the same question, the overwhelming choice would be Pinarayi Vijayan, the secretary of the state CPI(M) unit. Two conclusions could be drawn from this: one, that the party is totally out of sync with the people's mood; two, that Marxists like being ruled by an iron fist, hence their vote for Vijayan.

What Winston Churchill had said of the Soviet Union nearly half a century ago could be an accurate description of the 63-year-old Vijayan: "he remains a riddle wrapped in a mystery inside an enigma". Though, a Marxist, he is fond of boasting that he was one of the first Indian communist leaders to visit the Pope in the Vatican.

He talks of workers' rights, but presides over a party that runs several money-spinning businesses, including a TV channel and a newspaper. He takes to the pulpit to give stern lectures about probity, but chooses to remain silent when his close aides are caught with their hands in the till. On issues like foreign investment and private sector, he has refreshingly new ideas different from those of conservative rivals in the party. Not long ago, he was tipped to be Kerala's Buddhadev Bhattacharya, who would liberate the state CPI(M) from its outdated slogans and policies and become the harbinger of fundamental reforms like the Bengal chief minister.

Today, Vijayan's political prospects lie tattered. He is more likely to be equated with Boris Yeltsin, the mostly **DOWNSWING: Vijayan's image is taking a battering day by day**



SHANKAR